

Why Does Tongues Build Us Up?

The Question Is Not Whether Tongues Edifies, but How

Now that we know praying in tongues helps us mortify the deeds of the body, and we know it edifies and charges us up on our most holy faith, the question is: how?

This is the basics of prayer. How does it happen? How does sitting in a chair, walking back and forth in a living room, or circling an auditorium while praying in tongues hour after hour increase anyone's faith?

I asked God this. How does speaking syllables into the air increase faith? Do I have to interpret every phrase of tongues I speak out of my spirit? No. Can I pray in tongues hour after hour and still receive edification even if I do not interpret each sentence? Yes.

But how does praying in tongues build you up on your most holy faith?

When I asked those who seemed to be somewhat among us, many would break down the word "edify" in the Greek. They would explain that it means to build up, like charging a battery. For a long time I accepted that third-grade explanation.

After spending months in prayer, I went into some of my first meetings, laid hands on a woman, and she fell under the power. I thought, "Negative, positive, in Jesus' name, 220 volts." I ignorantly believed that the more I prayed in tongues, the more I received some kind of substance charge in my spirit that would be released when I laid hands on someone.

Then others explained that to edify means to build an edifice, a superstructure designed to house something. So they said praying in tongues builds a structure in the spirit to house the anointing of God.

But the question remained: why? How does speaking syllables in the air charge anyone up on his most holy faith?

Confusion About Tongues Has Turned Many Away From the Gift

If there is one area where the church is confused, it is speaking with tongues. It has turned much of the church world off because we have abused it without understanding it.

You finally talk a friend into coming to church. They sit on the back row next to Sister Holy Ghost, and right on cue she lets out a shout and starts jerking around. Your friend asks, "What is going on?"

You say, "The Holy Ghost is on her."

"Who? Is that God?"

"Yes, God is on her."

"Why is her neck jerking?"

"She is feeling the anointing."

Then you ask, "Would you like to receive the Holy Ghost?"

They answer, "No, thank you. I was at the chiropractor last month."

How do you think that looks to the world?

Some preachers also change their voices when they preach and call it the anointing. They speak normally in conversation, then step into the pulpit and suddenly sound like a different person. I asked God why they do that. He said, "That is their reaction to the anointing."

Some reactions are just that: reactions. You do not have to go wild to prove God is moving. I do not mind shouting, rejoicing, and running, but I do not want people turned off from the Holy Ghost by behavior we have mistaken for Him.

The devil loves to get into something precious and make a mess of it until people stop using it. Some people say they can only pray in tongues when they are emotional, crying, or under a heavy anointing. But tongues for personal edification is not limited to emotional moments.

So I asked again: Father, why are we edified when we pray in tongues hour after hour?

First Corinthians 14 Says Tongues Speak to God, Not Men

First Corinthians 14 begins:

Follow after charity, and desire spiritual gifts, but rather that ye may prophesy.

When Paul said "rather that ye may prophesy," he was exhorting the Corinthian church as individual believers to desire to edify the whole body. He was not saying prophecy is more important than praying in tongues in every sense. In the public assembly, prophecy edifies the church, so believers should desire to be used that way.

Then he says:

For he that speaketh in an unknown tongue speaketh not unto men, but unto God: for no man understandeth him; howbeit in the spirit he speaketh mysteries.

When I pray in tongues for personal edification, I am not talking to you. I am talking to God. That is why yelling tongues at the devil is confused. You are speaking to God, and He is not deaf. He is right there with you.

No man understands this language because it was not designed for men to understand. In tongues for personal edification, only the Father understands.

So Paul uses the word "howbeit." In other words, if I am praying in tongues, I do not understand me, and you do not understand me, and this is not a tongue to be interpreted, then what is happening in the realm of the Spirit?

Paul answers:

| In the spirit he speaketh mysteries.

Four Diversities of Tongues Must Not Be Governed by One Rule

Tongues for personal edification is only one of four diversities of tongues. Jude says:

| Building up yourselves on your most holy faith, praying in the Holy Ghost.

He did not say only tongues for personal edification, because "praying in the Holy Ghost" covers the whole spectrum of Spirit-empowered prayer.

The first diversity is tongues for personal edification. This is the one in which you speak to God.

The second is tongues that present themselves in a public assembly for interpretation.

The third extends into the deep intercessional groanings of the Spirit, empowering you to stand in the gap for your life, your family, your city, or your nation before God. It is as if God places you between sinners and hell.

The fourth is tongues as a sign to the unbeliever. This is when the Holy Spirit comes on you and creates a language inside you, and when you speak it, you testify, preach, or speak in a language you have never learned.

If you try to govern all four diversities by the same rules, you will end up confused.

Tongues as a Sign Lets the Spirit Speak a Known Language You Never Learned

Tongues as a sign to the unbeliever has happened to me nine times, mostly overseas. Imagine being in Germany with a German-speaking crowd, and your only translator collapses. You could either raise the translator from the dead and say, "No one gets out of my services that easily," or you could yield to the Holy Spirit and hear yourself preach in German.

Nine times out of ten, you will not know what you are saying, but the people will understand it. That is a sign to the unbeliever.

The last time it happened to me was at a camp meeting with Bill Basansky. He speaks Russian, and so does his mother. Charles Capps was there. I had taught that night, and then I broke out worshipping and praising God, making whole statements in Russian.

Bill pulled me into the back room, got Charles Capps as a witness, and asked, "Do you speak Russian?"

I said, "No."

"Do you speak any other language?"

"Only broken English."

He said, "You were praising God in complete phrases in Russian and glorifying Him."

We do not have to concern ourselves too much with that gift because it operates as the Spirit wills. But we can concern ourselves with the first diversity, the one Paul describes when he says the person speaking in an unknown tongue speaks not to men but to God.

Tongues for Personal Edification Is the Ultimate Closet Experience

When I pray in tongues for personal edification, my spirit enters an intimate relationship with God. It is the ultimate closet experience. You go into the holiest place, shut the door behind you, and your spirit is locked into fellowship with God's Spirit. You communicate directly with the Father in a supernatural language out of your spirit.

I know speaking with tongues edifies me. It charges me up. It builds an inner structure. But how does it do that when my mind does not understand?

First Corinthians 14:14 says:

For if I pray in an unknown tongue, my spirit prayeth, but my understanding is unfruitful.

The whole church world has asked us, "Why do you do it?" Too often we have not given sufficient answers. We say, "It edifies me." They ask, "How?" We say, "It builds me up on my most holy faith." They ask, "But faith comes by hearing, and hearing by the Word of God. If you do not understand what you are praying, how does it build your faith?"

For a long time, we did not know how to answer.

Mysteries Are Divine Secrets Beyond Natural Apprehension

The answer is in that word "howbeit."

How is this? What is happening in the Spirit when I pray in tongues? Paul says:

In the spirit he speaketh mysteries.

If I could understand what Paul meant by mysteries, then I could understand why praying in the Holy Ghost produces such an increase of faith.

The word "mysteries" means divine secrets: that which is out of the range of unassisted natural apprehension and can be made known only by divine intervention.

When I pray in tongues, I speak divine secrets before the Father. I knew my answer was in that word, so I took it apart with Greek helps, interlinears, Wuest, Strong's, and everything I could find.

What I found was this: Paul is talking about the same mysteries that were hidden in God before the foundation of the world but have now been made available to the church in this dispensation of grace. The mystery is Christ in you, the hope of glory.

When I pray in tongues, I am praying mysteries of Christ in me, to me, and through me, the hope of glory.

Mysteries Are Prayed for Our Benefit, Not God's

The mysteries you speak before God are not for God's benefit. What divine secret are you going to whisper into His ear that He did not know millennia before you were born?

He knows everything about you. He knows your problems, what causes them, and how to walk you out of them. He knows how to send you to feeding stations where you can be nourished. He knows how important gathering together is, praying together, learning together, fighting the devil together, and holding one another up.

The mysteries are for your benefit.

Praying in tongues is like any other kind of prayer. The prayer of faith moves mountains. The prayer of consecration says, "Lord, if it be Your will, I will go." The prayer of commitment, the prayer of love, the prayer of intercession, and supplication all have their place. Praying in tongues is also prayer, and it is not designed to go unanswered.

But the way God answers it is unique.

Revelation Answers the Mysteries You Pray

You may mentally assent to a verse for ten years. You know, "He bore my sicknesses and carried my pains," but you cannot seem to get it out of your head and into your heart. You try to use that verse against disease, but it remains only in your intellect.

Then you pray in tongues. He that searches the heart knows the mind of the Spirit and makes intercession according to the will of God. He knows your problem. When you pray in tongues, He searches your heart and prays God's will concerning that problem.

Paul prayed in tongues more than the Corinthians. I can imagine him walking mile after mile, praying in the Spirit. Then the Holy Ghost says, "Those mysteries you have been praying of Christ in you, the hope of glory? I am ready to answer." Suddenly the mysteries begin feeding through his spirit, and he writes them to the Romans, the Colossians, the Galatians, and the Corinthians.

The reason you are edified by praying in tongues is that you have a copy of the original mysteries in your lap: the canon of Scripture, the doctrine of Jesus Christ in you, the hope of glory. You read a verse you have not understood, then pray in tongues, and God begins answering the mysteries. Suddenly that verse comes alive: "He bore my sickness and carried my pains." Faith rises, and disease leaves.

That is building yourself up on your most holy faith, praying in the Holy Ghost.

John G. Lake Connected Tongues With Power and Revelation

John G. Lake came out of John Alexander Dowie's ministry in Zion. In the days when people traveled by horse, buggy, and train, Dowie had ten thousand people attending meetings in Zion.

Three invalids in John G. Lake's family were healed under Dowie's anointing. That so affected Lake that it launched him into a healing ministry.

Lake later wrote with great frankness about the language of tongues he mostly spoke at night. He said it was not only the source of the power he operated in day by day, but also an invaluable source of revelation knowledge he preached.

John G. Lake had so many recorded miracles in Spokane that the city was greatly affected. They could bring diseased people into a clinical room, and when he laid hands on them, several would be instantly healed while others recovered over time. We have very little like that today.

Those men attributed much to the walk of the Spirit.

Organization Must Never Replace Responsibility for God's Power

I am for organization, helps, governments, visitation, and soul-winning programs. Many of you are called to such work. But if you replace your responsibility for the power of God with organizational concepts, then what will you do with the people once you get them here?

God wants to meet needs on both ends. He wants helps and governments functioning so the smallest believer on the outskirts of a large operation receives what he needs. But He also wants a devastating move of power flowing through the services and meeting people's needs.

You cannot abandon responsibility for prayer and power. I am going to keep pressing you until you pray enough to turn yourself over to the Holy Spirit, until you are consumed with God and consumed with revival.

Dead complacency and irresponsibility must die. When you are consumed with God and with this generation being lost, revival will organize you into soul-winning teams. You will leave church services with one thing on your mind: find someone, get them born again, nourish them into the baptism of the Holy Spirit, get them healed, and train them until they can do the same for someone else.

Do a first-class job at work. Do your vocation well. But work on people until you get them into the kingdom, and when they begin doing what you are doing, go get someone else.

Your Problem Is Not Bigger Than God

Do not be so discouraged that you need a cheerleader to get you to serve God. You may understand your problem well, but it is not bigger than God.

If God is worried about your problem, then you have a good reason to worry. But if He is not worried, you are wasting your time.

There is a place in Him where peace lives. I wish I could take a spiritual saw and open your spirit and put peace in. I wish I could put the love of God and the understanding of righteousness in you. These are great mysteries held in God.

But I can introduce you to a Gentleman: the third person of the Godhead. If you will do what He says and begin praying in tongues, He will speak mysteries through you. God will respond to those mysteries, turn you over to Jesus, and Jesus will become all these things in you: the hope of glory.

What your carnal mind could not fathom will come alive in you. It is at this level that transformation takes place.

Pray in the Spirit and Let Him Teach You to Hear

In the basics of prayer, I would say: pray in tongues. Come Wednesday night and pray. Come early Sunday morning and pray. Fast. Search for God with all your heart.

Let Him purge you from the sins of the flesh. Put off the old man. Stop lying. Stop complacency. Stop indifference. Turn yourself over to the Holy Ghost, and He will use you for many things.

The Spirit of grace says: I have revealed these things to you, seeing some of your slow hearing and dull insight. Allow Me to fellowship with you by My mighty Holy Spirit, for He is My power and My might. I will edify and build you up into places of My Spirit. I will anoint your eyes to see many things that have held you in bondage, and they will turn loose. I will set you free.

Stay consistent in the Spirit of grace. In your thinking, give Me first place. I will lift you and anoint you with understanding from on high. I will show you, through the power of My Spirit, how to have the old man die. I will give you peace beyond compare and the kind of joy that, when you enter My presence, you find Me there.

So, My children, why worry? Why walk in fear? Prepare yourself. Pray in the Spirit, and I will draw near so that you may hear what the Spirit says to the church.